

# 8

effective working practices

## How You Work

the professional craft that wraps around the technical work

Seven days of technical work. Power Query, the Cleaning Sequence, merges, descriptive stats, regression, pivots, dashboard polish. Today's content sits at a different layer — the *behaviour* layer that wraps around all of it.

Three things matter most: how you **talk to different audiences** (because Priya, a peer data tech, and a brand-new starter all need different things), how you **structure findings** (so they land), and how you **carry yourself as a professional** (because the EPA grades this just as hard as your Power Query skills).

Today's named device is **Three Audiences, Three Voices**. The framework you'll hear again and again is **Headline → Evidence → Caveat**. Both will be in your head by lunch.

*Today is the soft stuff. Why does it matter so much?*

— you, briefly suspicious of the agenda

*Because two candidates with identical technical work get different grades. This is the difference.*

and it's all learnable.



### BRAIN POWER

Think of a time someone explained something to you in the *wrong* voice — too technical when you wanted plain English, or too dumbed-down when you wanted detail. What did that feel like? That's the experience your audience has if you pick the wrong voice.

turn over — the meeting went well →

# The meeting went well

Priya took your dashboard into the exec meeting and came back with a thank-you. Now's the moment to look back at how you actually got there — and how you'd do it again.

## REFLECT

- which audience?
- which voice?
- headline - evidence
- caveat

what would I do differently?

You:

"One click on Refresh.  
First of every month,  
it'll be ready by lunch.  
No rework."

## Teams — Priya M.

Priya M. • 14:12

That dashboard went down well 🎉

Priya M. • 14:13

Exec asked good questions. The "1 in 3 in their first year" number really landed.

Priya M. • 14:14

Can we make this monthly? 🙏

DAY 8

## Three Audiences, Three Voices

The single biggest soft-skill miss in EPA presentations is using the *same voice for everyone*. Same Excel finding, same words, same level of detail — whether you're briefing the CEO, your manager, or a brand-new colleague who joined yesterday. You can almost see the assessor's pen hovering.

The fix is built into one rule: **pick the audience first, then pick the voice**. Same finding, three voices, depending on who's listening.

### The three audiences

You'll meet variations of these three for the rest of your career:

- **The Exec.** Senior, time-poor, decision-focused. Wants the headline number and what to *do* about it. Doesn't care how Power Query merges work.
- **The Peer.** Another data person, or someone with technical depth (an analyst, a developer). Wants the methodology — what you joined on, what you cleaned, what you'd refine next.
- **The New Starter.** Joined yesterday. Wants the *process* — how you decided where to start, what the named devices mean, how it all fits together.

*If you can tell the same story three ways, you understand it.*

*If you can only tell it one way, you've memorised it.*

#### ASSESSOR FAVOURITE

The assessor often *plays an audience*: "explain this to your manager", then "now explain it to a junior team member". They're not testing the same answer twice — they're testing whether you can switch voices. Be ready.

## The voices in action

Same finding from Day 4 — "churn is highest among new subscribers" — told three different ways. Read each. Notice how the words, the length, and the level of detail change. Notice what stays constant.

### → TO THE EXEC (ONE SENTENCE)

*"One in three subscribers cancel in their first 12 months — that's where retention spend should focus."*

### → TO A PEER DATA TECH (A PARAGRAPH)

*"I bucketed tenure\_months into 6-month bands using =IFS , then ran a PivotTable with bands in Rows and a calculated churn-rate column. Churn in the 0–6 month band is 51%, dropping to 18% in 12–24, and single digits beyond 24.  $R^2$  of tenure-vs-churn on the bucketed data was 0.74. Survey responses point to PRICE as the dominant reason in early-tenure cancellations — worth a follow-up."*

### → TO A NEW STARTER (A COUPLE OF PARAGRAPHS, NO JARGON)

*"So we wanted to know: are people who've just signed up more likely to cancel than people who've been with us for a few years? We started by working out how long each subscriber had been with StreamWave — that's just today minus their join date, in months. We call that their 'tenure.'"*

*"Then we counted what proportion of each tenure band had cancelled. New subscribers (less than 6 months in) churned at 51%. People past their second year were down at under 10%. So yes — newer subscribers cancel a lot more than longer-term ones. The survey suggests it's mostly about price for the new ones."*

Same finding. Three voices. Notice how the structure of each — number, context, what-to-do-about-it — stays consistent. Only the depth, the jargon, and the length change.

## Headline → Evidence → Caveat

Inside every voice — exec, peer, or new starter — the structure stays the same. For every finding you present, three pieces:

1. **Headline.** The finding in plain English. No numbers yet. *One sentence.*
2. **Evidence.** The number(s) that back the headline. *One sentence.*
3. **Caveat.** What you're not sure about, or what the analysis didn't cover. *One sentence.*

### A worked example — the churn finding

**Headline:** *"Churn is concentrated in subscribers under one year tenured — that's where we should focus retention."*

**Evidence:** *"Of the 31% who cancelled, two-thirds were in their first 12 months. After 24 months, churn drops to single digits."*

**Caveat:** *"This doesn't tell us why they're churning. Survey responses point to price, but the sample is small and self-selected."*

### Why the caveat *builds* credibility, not undermines it

Newer data techs worry that caveats weaken a finding. They don't. They **build trust**. A finding without a caveat sounds like a salesperson. A finding *with* a caveat sounds like an analyst. Priya — or the assessor — will trust the next number you bring them *more* because you were honest about the limits of the last one.

#### SHOW THIS OFF

For every question about your findings, answer in three sentences. Headline. Evidence. Caveat. Practise until it feels automatic. *"Churn is highest in the first year. Two-thirds of cancellations happen within 12 months. Why isn't established — survey responses point to price but the sample is small."* Three sentences, every time.

## Documentation that travels

You won't be the only person who ever opens this workbook. A colleague will pick it up next month to refresh it, or take it over while you're on leave, or use it as the template for a different dataset.

Documentation is what makes that handover possible without a phone call.

### The five things every methodology note contains

Live in a cell at the bottom of the dashboard. Three or four sentences. Five ingredients:

1. **Data sources.** Which files, where they live on disk, who owns them. *"Source: five StreamWave files in / Data/, owned by the CRM team."*
2. **Last refresh date.** Either typed manually each refresh, or use `=TEXT(NOW(), "dd mmm yyyy")` on a cell that updates when the workbook opens.
3. **Key transformations.** One sentence naming the named devices you used. *"Cleaned via the Cleaning Sequence; merged via Left Outer joins on the canonical subscriber\_id."*
4. **Key assumptions.** What you took for granted that someone else might not. *"Tenure bucketed as 0-6 / 6-12 / 12-24 / 24+ months. Churn defined as status = 'cancelled' regardless of cancel date."*
5. **Known limitations.** The caveats from your findings, in one place. *"Survey sample is small and self-selected; YoY comparison uses Q3 partial sample for 2024."*

### Beyond the methodology cell — three more places documentation lives

- **Applied Steps** in each Power Query, renamed in plain English (right-click any step → Rename).
- **Table-column references** in formulas (`tblActivity[duration]` instead of `E:E`) — self-documenting.
- **Comments on key cells** (right-click → Insert Comment / Note) for anything that isn't obvious from the formula itself.

#### SHOW THIS OFF

When asked about documentation, narrate the *handover scenario*: *"If I were off sick next week and a colleague had to refresh this, they'd open the Applied Steps in each query to see the transformations, read the methodology cell to see the assumptions, and look at the table-column references in the formulas. They wouldn't need to call me."*

# Halfway House

Four scenarios — pick the right voice. Answers below the line.

1. The CEO has thirty seconds in a corridor. You need to land the churn finding.

☐ **Exec voice**   ☐ **Peer voice**   ☐ **New Starter voice**

2. Another data analyst wants to use your method for a different project. They ask how you handled the subscriber\_id mismatch.

☐ **Exec voice**   ☐ **Peer voice**   ☐ **New Starter voice**

3. An apprentice who started last week shadowed your demo and asks "what is Power Query, actually?"

☐ **Exec voice**   ☐ **Peer voice**   ☐ **New Starter voice**

4. Priya emails the exec team your dashboard. The Finance Director replies: "Why is churn so high in the first year?"

☐ **Exec voice**   ☐ **Peer voice**   ☐ **New Starter voice**

## Answers — check yourself

1. **Exec voice.** One sentence, with the action implied. *"One in three subscribers churn in the first year — that's where retention spend should go."*

2. **Peer voice.** Methodology, technical detail, named devices. *"Three different ID formats — five-digit text, integer, SW-prefix. I standardised them with Replace Values and Column from Examples."*

3. **New Starter voice.** Slow, jargon-free, build from basics. *"Power Query is Excel's data-prep tool — you tell it where the data lives, what to clean, and how to merge tables, and it runs that recipe every time the data refreshes."*

4. **Exec voice + caveat.** The FD wants the *why*, so headline-first with the caveat in plain English. *"Survey responses point to price for early-tenure cancellations. Sample's small, so worth a deeper look."*

# Stakeholders

A data tech rarely works in isolation. Five kinds of stakeholder typically circle any analysis — each wanting something different. Knowing who's who is half the job; *delivering what each one needs* is the other half.

| Stakeholder              | What they want                       | How you deliver it                                                               |
|--------------------------|--------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Sponsor (Priya)          | Reliable answers, on time            | Dashboard + Headline → Evidence → Caveat email                                   |
| Exec                     | Headline + decision                  | Exec voice. One sentence. One number.                                            |
| Peers (other data techs) | Methodology, reusable patterns       | Peer voice. Walk through the named devices.                                      |
| IT / data engineering    | Source-system info, refresh schedule | A short list of files, their locations, and what refresh cadence you've assumed. |
| The Assessor             | Evidence of process, not just result | Narrate as you work. Name your devices. Caveat your findings.                    |

## When stakeholders disagree

Two stakeholders ask for opposite things — for example, the exec wants the dashboard simplified, but a peer wants more methodological detail. The answer isn't to please one and ignore the other. The answer is to **separate the deliverables**: one polished dashboard for the exec, with a methodology appendix for the peer. Same source data, two presentations. Both stakeholders get what they need.

### ASSESSOR FAVOURITE

The question "*who were the stakeholders in this project?*" is almost always asked. The strong answer names **at least three different stakeholders** and describes **what each one needed differently**. Listing roles without describing different needs is a Pass; describing the differences is a Distinction.



# CPD & multi-functional teamwork

## CPD — Continuing Professional Development

The EPA expects you to be the kind of data tech who *keeps learning*. CPD isn't a tick-box exercise; it's the habit of staying current on the tools, the techniques, and the data landscape. In practice it looks like:

- **A short learning log.** One line per week. *"This week I learned how to do bucket grouping in PivotTables for unequal ranges using IFS."* That's enough.
- **One conference, course, or community per year.** Doesn't need to be expensive — local data meetups, free Microsoft Learn modules, a SQL course on YouTube. Have a thing you can name.
- **Reading a thing.** One book a year, or a regular blog. *Edward Tufte* for visualisation, *Cole Knaflig* for storytelling-with-data — pick a teacher to follow.
- **Reflection.** Every project, write down one thing you'd do differently next time. Otherwise you'll do it the same way next time. (That's the reason today's post-it says *"what would I do differently?"*.)

## Multi-functional teams

Modern data work happens in mixed teams. You won't be sitting next to other data techs all day. Around you will typically be:

- **Business analysts** — they know the questions; you know the data.
- **Software engineers** — they own the systems your data comes from.
- **Domain experts** (marketing, finance, ops) — they know what's *plausible*; if your number looks weird, ask them first.
- **Project managers** — they care about deadlines and dependencies, not your join logic.

Working well in mixed teams means knowing *which voice* to use with each of them (Day 8's whole topic), and being honest about what you don't know. A data tech who says *"I don't know — let me check with the marketing team and come back"* is more valuable than one who guesses.

# Inclusive working & ethics

Two topics that get less airtime than they should — both grade-able in AM2, both genuinely important.

## Inclusive working — in the data and in the dashboard

**In the data:** who's *missing*? Every dataset has gaps. StreamWave's data covers UK subscribers with email accounts and bank details — that excludes people without those things. If your finding is "*Premium subscribers prefer Documentary content*", that's a finding about a subset of the population, not all viewers. Be honest about who your data describes.

**In the dashboard:** accessibility matters. Three practical rules:

- **Colour-blind safe.** Don't rely on red-and-green alone — pair them with icons or text labels. About 8% of men can't distinguish them reliably.
- **Readable contrast.** Dark text on light backgrounds (or vice versa). Excel's default light grey text on white fails accessibility checks.
- **Plain language.** "Churn rate" beats "voluntary cancellation propensity index". Every time.

## Ethics beyond GDPR

Day 7 covered the GDPR rules. Ethics goes further. Three principles that come up in AM2:

- **Honesty.** Don't paint a finding green because it looks better. Don't truncate an axis to make a trend look steeper. The number is the number.
- **Transparency.** If a finding has a caveat, the caveat lives *with the finding*, not in an appendix nobody reads. Caveats build trust.
- **Pushing back.** When a stakeholder asks you to remove a caveat, or pick a chart that flatters a number — say no. Politely, with reasoning, but say no. Doing what you're told isn't what an analyst is for.

### ASSESSOR FAVOURITE

The hypothetical "*a senior leader asks you to remove a caveat — what do you do?*" is a near-certain question. The one-sentence answer: "*I'd explain why the caveat is there in business terms — that removing it would over-state our confidence in the number — and offer to reword it so it's less prominent without losing the meaning.*" Polite push-back, with a constructive alternative. That's the answer.



## SHARPEN YOUR PENCIL one finding, three voices

Take this finding from Day 5: *"tenure\_months and total\_watch\_hours have a positive linear relationship with  $R^2$  of 0.71."* Write it three times — once for each audience. Don't peek at page 4 until you've drafted yours.

### 1. To the Exec (one sentence):

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### 2. To a Peer Data Tech (a paragraph):

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### 3. To a New Starter (a couple of sentences, no jargon):

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## Sample answers — compare with yours

**1. Exec:** *"Longer-tenured subscribers do watch more — about an extra 1.4 hours per month of tenure."*

**2. Peer:** *"Built a per-subscriber summary table with tenure\_months (via DATEDIF) and total\_watch\_hours (SUMIF on activity). Scatter with linear trendline:  $y = 1.4x + 9.2$ ,  $R^2 = 0.71$ . Tenure explains about 71% of variation; plan type and region almost certainly play a role too — worth segmenting before claiming causation."*

**3. New Starter:** *"We asked: do people who've been with us longer watch more? We worked out each subscriber's tenure and total watch time, drew a scatter plot, and added a line of best fit. The line slopes up — so yes, longer-tenured people watch more. Roughly 1.4 extra hours per month of tenure. About 70% of the variation is explained by tenure; the rest is down to other factors we haven't looked at yet."*

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## There are no *Dumb* Questions

**Q:** *What if I genuinely don't know what voice the audience expects?*

**A:** Pitch slightly toward the new-starter voice first, watch for cues, then ratchet up. "Watch them nod or frown" is the technique. Better to be too clear than too cryptic — you can always add detail; you can't easily take confusion away.

**Q:** *Is "Headline → Evidence → Caveat" too rigid? Sometimes a finding is more complex.*

**A:** For a single finding, it's the right structure 95% of the time. For complex findings with multiple parts, use it for each part — same three-sentence shape for the headline, the regional breakdown, and the survey angle. Three findings, nine sentences, same framework throughout.

**Q:** *What if my stakeholder doesn't want a caveat?*

**A:** Then it's part of your job to deliver one anyway, politely. Caveats build trust over time. The stakeholder who pushes back on caveats this week is the same one who'll trust your numbers in three months. Hold the line constructively.

**Q:** *Documentation feels like extra work nobody reads. Is it really worth it?*

**A:** You'll be the colleague picking up someone else's work next quarter. Documentation is a kindness you pay forward. It's also a near-guaranteed AM2 question — be ready with a real example, not a theoretical one.

**Q:** *How do I keep a CPD log without it feeling like homework?*

**A:** One line per Friday. Not a paragraph. "*Learned bucket grouping in PivotTables.*" A whole year's CPD log fits on one A4 page. The act of writing it makes the learning stick.

**Q:** *What if the assessor disagrees with my interpretation?*

**A:** Listen properly. Then either accept the point and adjust ("good catch — that's a fair limitation I hadn't surfaced"), or hold your ground with reasoning ("I see the concern, and the reason I structured it this way was..."). Both responses score — what loses marks is going silent or flip-flopping.

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*Pick the audience. Pick the voice. Headline · Evidence · Caveat. Same three moves, every finding.*

## Say it out loud

Three questions to rehearse out loud. Same finding, different angles. The assessor will ask variations of these every time.

### Q1 — Who were your stakeholders, and what did each need differently?

Name **at least three**. Don't just list roles; describe what each one needed. *"Priya, my manager, needed a reliable monthly answer she could take to exec. The exec team needed a one-page dashboard they could absorb in 30 seconds. A peer data tech needed methodology — what I joined on, what I cleaned, the named devices I used. Three audiences, three different deliverables built from the same source."*

### Q2 — How would you explain this analysis to someone who joined yesterday?

Switch to the new-starter voice. Slow. No jargon. Build from basics. *"We had five files — subscribers, what they watched, the titles, who cancelled, and a survey. The trick was getting them to talk to each other, because the same subscriber had three different IDs across the files. We cleaned that up, joined them, then looked for patterns. The big one was that newer subscribers cancel a lot more than long-term ones."*

### Q3 — Tell me about a limitation in your analysis.

Lead with the caveat. **Do not hedge or apologise for the analysis.** Naming a limitation confidently is a Distinction move. *"The biggest one is that the survey is small and self-selected. Subscribers who fill in a satisfaction survey aren't a random sample — they're more likely to be the ones with strong opinions. So I'd trust the survey for direction but not for precise percentages. The next step would be a proper sample of all cancellers."*



#### **DISTINCTION TELL**

The assessor cares whether you can *switch voices on demand*. If they ask "explain this to your manager", then "now explain it to a new starter", they're not testing whether you remember the answer — they're testing whether you can adjust. Practise both versions of each question, out loud, so the switch feels natural.

## Bullet Points — the chapter in 30 seconds

- **Three Audiences, Three Voices.** Exec, Peer, New Starter. Same finding told three ways.
- **Headline → Evidence → Caveat.** Three sentences, every finding, every audience.
- **Caveats build trust.** A finding with limitations sounds like an analyst; one without sounds like a salesperson.
- **Documentation that travels.** Methodology cell + Applied Steps + table-column references = handover without a phone call.
- **Name three stakeholders** and describe how each needs different things — Distinction-band answer.
- **CPD is one line a week.** Reflection beats hours of "training".
- **Push back politely** when a stakeholder asks for something that compromises honesty.

## TEST DRIVE

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- ☐ You can give the same finding in three different voices without referring back to notes.
- ☐ You can structure any finding as Headline → Evidence → Caveat in under a minute.
- ☐ You can name three stakeholders for your StreamWave project and what each needs.
- ☐ You have a one-paragraph methodology note for your dashboard.
- ☐ You can describe a limitation in your analysis confidently, without apologising for the analysis.

### COMING UP — DAY 9

**Handling the Questioning.** The final technical day before the mocks. How the assessor's questions actually work — four kinds, each wanting a different shape of answer. The *Listen → Repeat → Frame → Answer → Check* technique. Handling hypotheticals, handling "I don't know", and the post-demo Q&A format specifically.

that's Day 8 done — the soft skills are now muscle memory.